

LOCOMOTIF | S. PRASANNARAJAN

Capital Paradoxes



It is a strange place, Delhi in summer, and the strangeness continues to be exaggerated by the multiplying effect of irony and paradox. It is a city where the pathology of power is only matched by the bathos of the fallen and the falling. Look. It all began with an amateur in political Delhi caught between power and freedom, and his existential crisis transmitted to the world in tweets, the haiku of cyber-poets who narrate their life stories in 140 characters. He had written books, but he was not exactly Vaclav Havel, or even a Michael Ignatieff. While in power, in retrospect, he was not what he could have been. He could have given Delhi, steeped in durbar intrigues and ethical elasticity, a break from politics-us-usual. He could have added a dash of cultural sophistication to the Government's diplomatic endeavours. His refusal to be one of them, or his non-conformism, was admirable, but in the end, he was another flawed individual with a formidable intellect, and his tragedy was further accelerated by his own political dispensability. Still, in his fall, his political employers must have felt a sense of moral elation, that too at a lower price. What happened next was worthy of bigger headlines, and the script of cricket and politics was being played out by bigger daddies of the game.

Predictably, the apostles of clean government had to disarm themselves when the exigencies of power triumphed over the pretence of morality. It was as if the script needed only one bogeyman. Midnight knockers and other sundry votaries of fair play are still at work, but does the

exorcism of one evil spirit alone mean liberation?

Certainly not. For his admirers, our prime minister is a byword for political morality and moderation. And he has started taking his role as the elder statesman of the global high tables quite seriously. In a world of the dour (Gordon Brown) and the reckless (Nicolas Sarkozy) and the debutantes (Barack Obama), he is the wise old man from the East. He sacked his favourite boy for the sake of ministerial propriety and transparency. And that was the first thing he did on his return from an international trip. What about another minister who has allegedly misused his powers under "family" pressure? What about the extra-ministerial interests of some of his cabinet colleagues? Well, it requires a higher sense of political morality to forsake power. The true mark of a conviction politician is his ability to defy—or redeem—the system. In Delhi 2010, the distance between pretence and principle is being reduced by the banality of power, and sadly, the one man who could have played the last moralist of Indraprastha has chosen to be a parody of the finest adjectives attributed to him.

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SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Rajasthan governor **Prabha Rau**, 75. She had held several MoS portfolios, was a six-time Congress MLA, MP and ex-governor of Himachal Pradesh. She is the second



Rajasthan governor to have died in office in 2010 after her predecessor S.K. Singh's death in January.

AWARDED: To Congress leader **Karan Singh**, the fifth Paulos Mar Gregorios award for public service, culture and inter-faith dialogue. The award was instituted by Dr Paulos Mar Gregorios, the first bishop of the Delhi Diocese of the Indian Orthodox Church.

AWARDED: To **Rukhsana Kauser** and **Ajaz Ahmed**, who killed an LET division commander in Rajouri in September 2009, the Kirti Chakra by President Pratibha Patil. The award is the highest peacetime gallantry medal.

DIED: **Varkala Radhakrishnan**, 84, three-time Lok Sabha member from Kerala and four-time MLA. He was the Assembly Speaker from 1987 to 1991.